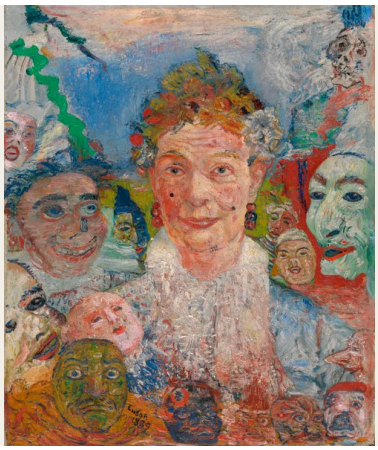
GHENT, BELGIUM

Museum of Fine Arts Ghent: Masterpieces

A selection from the Museum of Fine Arts that asks what a painted figure is doing—and what a title leads us to assume.



A shoemaker bends toward his bench. A girl stands with her hand near a door handle. An old woman sits amid masks whose expressions are louder than her own. These are different ways of making a person the subject of a picture: through an occupation, a momentary position or the company that surrounds them.

This selection moves between named sitters and figures presented as types, virtues or imagined characters. The distinction matters. A costume does not give us a biography, and a title such as *Desperation* can name an emotion without explaining the entire scene. The entries below begin with the situations the pictures establish, leaving room for what they do not tell us.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/fine-arts-ghent

The selection · 20

1. Old Woman with Masks
   James Ensor · 1889
2. Pastoral Scene
   John da Costa · 1892
3. Marguerite van Mons
   Théo van Rysselberghe · 1886
4. Greyhound Catching a Young Wild Boar
   Frans Snyders · c. 1620
5. An Abruzzi Woman Nursing Her Child
   Jacques Alfred van Muyden · 1850
6. Allegory of the Metal Industry
   Gustave De Keukelaere · c. 1913
7. Autumn Landscape
   Alfred Elsen · 1877
8. Bathing Woman
   William-Adolphe Bouguereau · 1864
9. The Shoemaker
   George Minne · 1887
10. Bottelare Park
    Armand Heins · c. 1910
11. Calvary
    Constantin Meunier · c. 1900
12. Card Players in an Italian Tavern
    Edouard De Jans · 1882
13. Charity
    Joseph Sacré · 1836
14. Coppice at Sint-Martens-Latem
    Albijn Van den Abeele · 1898
15. Covered Market and Guildhall in Ghent
    Armand Heins · 1883
16. Desperation
    Alexander Struys · 1894–1896
17. Equestrian Portrait
    Jacques de Lalaing · 1878
18. Nude with a Red Bird
    Frits van den Berghe · 1931
19. Feast at the Doge’s Palace in Venice
    Xavier Mellery · 1876
20. Female Slave with a Plate of Fruit
    Jules Joseph Lefebvre · c. 1874

01 / 20

Old Woman with Masks

James Ensor

1889 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



James Ensor. Old Woman with Masks (Theatre of Masks). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/james-ensor/old-woman-with-masks-theatre-of-masks-1889 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The masks make the old woman's face seem comparatively reserved, but their proximity denies her the space of a conventional portrait. Their expressions are ready-made and exaggerated; hers is harder to settle. The picture makes that difference worth attending to without requiring a decision about which face represents a more authentic self.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Pastoral Scene

John da Costa

1892 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



John da Costa. Pastoral Scene. Image credit: John da Costa; Source credit: Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The staff identifies an activity that the landscape alone would leave vague. Trees and grazing animals surround the girl, yet her upright stance gives the scene a centre on a human scale. She is part of the rural setting and a figure presented for attention, a balance that the label “pastoral” can too easily smooth over.

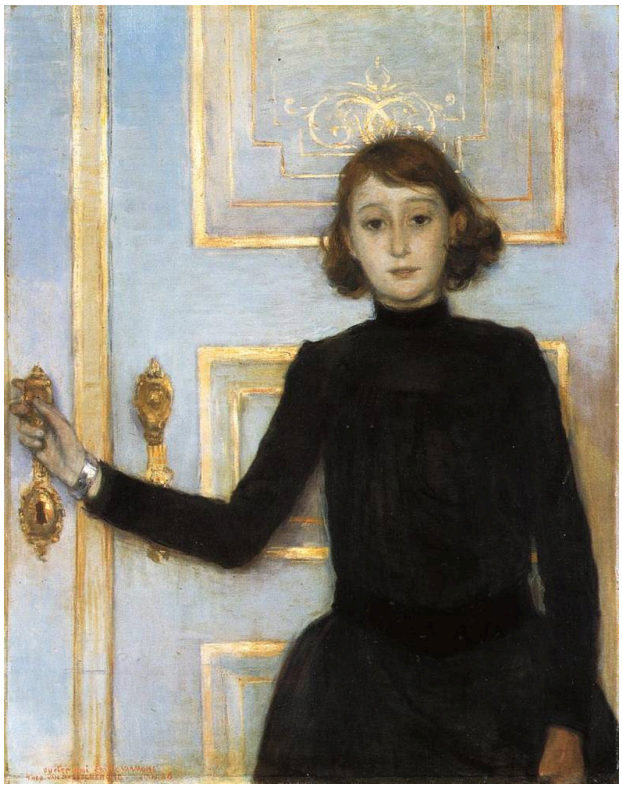
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1973-F

03 / 20

Marguerite van Mons

Théo van Rysselberghe

1886 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Théo van Rysselberghe. Portrait of Marguerite van Mons. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/theo-van-rysselberghe/portrait-of-marguerite-van-mons-1886 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The pale door makes the dark dress register as a nearly continuous shape. Then the hand near the handle complicates that stillness: this is a pose located where someone might enter or leave. Nothing proves that an interruption has occurred. The threshold simply gives the portrait a possibility of movement that its formal arrangement holds in check.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Greyhound Catching a Young Wild Boar

Frans Snyders

c. 1620 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Frans Snyders. A Greyhound Catching a Young Wild Boar. Image credit: Frans Snyders; https://mskgent.be/collection/work/data/1920-L. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Jong_everzwijn_gegrepen_door_een_jachthond,_Frans_Snyders,_1620,_Koninklijk_Museum_voor_Schone_Kunsten_Gent,_1920-L.jpg. CC0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · CC0

The dog's long limbs and the boar's compressed body make the unequal struggle readable before any surrounding detail. Plants help enclose the encounter rather than provide an escape from it. Snyders brings the pursuit to a point of physical contact, where the direction of one animal's movement becomes pressure on the other.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1920-L

05 / 20

An Abruzzi Woman Nursing Her Child

Jacques Alfred van Muyden

1850 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Jacques Alfred van Muyden. Abruzzi Woman with a Suckling Child. Image credit: Jacques Alfred van Muyden; Source credit: Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The curve of the image repeats the enclosure made by the mother's arms. Feeding, rather than an outward-facing pose, connects the two figures. Her cap and blouse establish the appearance of a particular costume, but the sustained action is simpler to identify: one body holds and supports another within a tightly bounded space.

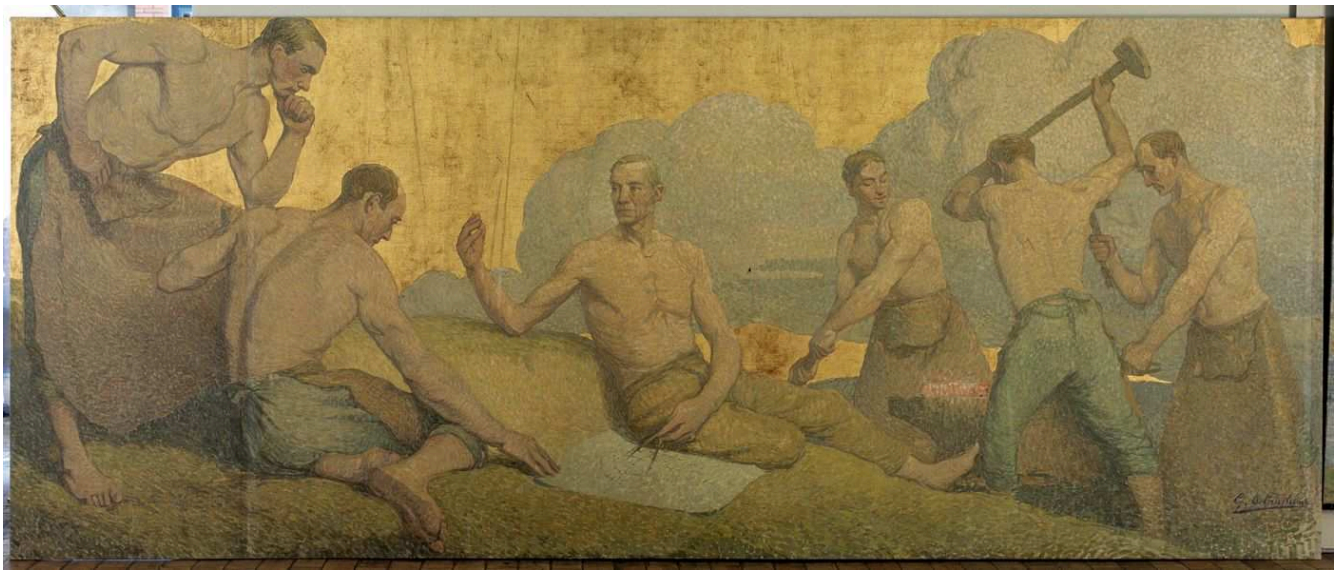
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1850-C

06 / 20

Allegory of the Metal Industry

Gustave De Keukelaere

c. 1913 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Gustave De Keukelaere; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

The workers' repeated poses organise the shallow space almost as a sequence of demonstrations. Tools connect the figures to metalworking, while the title asks them to stand for an entire industry. This is a useful distinction from Minne's shoemaker: an allegorical group represents a field of labour, rather than merely showing one person occupied at a bench.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1999-G

07 / 20

Autumn Landscape

Alfred Elsen

1877 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Alfred Elsen; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

The lighter opening between the trunks provides a way into the woodland. Brown leaves establish autumn, but the arrangement depends equally on the alternating density of trees and gaps. There is no need to invent a walker or an approaching event; the change from obstructed foreground to more open distance gives the view its movement.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1938-I

08 / 20

Bathing Woman

William-Adolphe Bouguereau

1864 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



William Bouguereau; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

The body's smooth boundary stands out against the irregular rock and foliage. The setting therefore does more than identify a place to bathe: it makes the figure's continuous contour especially legible. That contrast helps explain the picture's idealised presentation, without treating the imagined outdoor scene as an account of an ordinary encounter.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1865-C

09 / 20

The Shoemaker

George Minne

1887 · Pen in zwart, gewassen, en potlood op papier · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



George Minne; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

Rows of tools and shoe forms surround a body bent toward a demanding task. The worker's posture is understood through that equipment; it is not simply an expressive pose placed in a generic room. Compare the drawing with the nearby industrial allegory, where repeated bodies represent labour on a more public and generalised scale.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2003-AW

10 / 20

Bottelare Park

Armand Heins

c. 1910 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Armand Heins. Bottelare Park (Merelbeke). Image credit: Armand Heins; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Armand_Heins_-_Bottelare_Park_(Merelbeke)_-_1932-F_-_Museum_of_Fine_Arts_Ghent_(MSK).jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The path promises a passage through the park, but the dense vegetation limits how far it can be followed. Small lighter patches offer only partial openings in the dark greens. Instead of surveying a leisure ground from outside, the picture places attention within its enclosure, where a route is visible without its destination becoming clear.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1932-F

11 / 20

Calvary

Constantin Meunier

c. 1900 · Oil on panel · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Constantin Meunier; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

The rising road organises this procession before individual faces can be read. Bodies and a horse share the effort of moving over stony ground, and the group thickens farther up. The religious subject is carried by collective progress through a landscape, rather than being confined to a single isolated gesture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1928-AS

12 / 20

Card Players in an Italian Tavern

Edouard De Jans

1882 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Edouard De Jans; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

Heads and hands converge around a small area of tabletop. That shared attention makes the cards important even when their individual values are not the picture's clearest information. Standing figures tighten the gathering from outside it. The tavern becomes a place where playing and watching belong to the same social event.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1938-K

13 / 20

Charity

Joseph Sacré

1836 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Joseph Sacré; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

The difference between standing and sitting establishes an unequal relationship before the act of assistance is fully read. Sacré gives charity a bodily arrangement: someone is positioned to offer, another to receive. The religious setting reinforces the title's moral frame, but it is the exchange between figures that makes the abstract virtue visible.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: S-142

14 / 20

Coppice at Sint-Martens-Latem

Albijn Van den Abeele

1898 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Albijn Van den Abeele. Coppice at Sint-Martens-Latem. Image credit: Albijn Van den Abeele; Source credit: www.lukasweb.be – Art in Flanders. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

A path threads through closely spaced stems, giving the eye a route without a commanding destination. The repeated uprights are similar but not identical; their intervals keep the woodland from becoming a flat screen. This is a landscape whose structure can be found in ordinary growth, without distant peaks or dramatic weather.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1981-G

15 / 20

Covered Market and Guildhall in Ghent

Armand Heins

1883 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Armand Heins. Covered market and guildhall in Ghent. Image credit: Armand Heins; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Armand_Heins_-_The_Meat_House_in_Ghent_-_1934-V_-_Museum_of_Fine_Arts_Ghent_(MSK).jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The heavy timber framework establishes how much room the small workers and stalls occupy. Daylight enters in patches rather than lighting everything equally, dividing the busy interior into areas of different visibility. The architecture is understood through use: a market building contains repeated tasks and movements, not simply an impressive empty volume.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1934-V

16 / 20

Desperation

Alexander Struys

1894–1896 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Alexander Struys. Desperation. Image credit: Alexander Struys; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Alexander_Struys_-_Desperation_-_1899-J_-_Museum_of_Fine_Arts_Ghent_(MSK).jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The title supplies an emotional direction, while the lamplit gathering withholds many of the circumstances. Visitors and a seated figure occupy an unequal, shadowed space, and posture has to carry much of the encounter. It is worth resisting a complete invented story here. The obscurity is part of the situation the painting presents.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1899-J

17 / 20

Equestrian Portrait

Jacques de Lalaing

1878 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Jacques de Lalaing. Equestrian Portrait. Image credit: Jacques de Lalaing; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Jacques_de_Lalaing_-_Equestrian_Portrait_-_1886-E_-_Museum_of_Fine_Arts_Ghent_(MSK).jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The horse increases the sitter's physical scale, while the other mounted and uniformed figures give him a public setting. This is a likeness defined partly through company and position. Unlike a closely cropped face, it asks the surrounding space to participate in the portrait, making rank visible through an organised outdoor gathering.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1886-E

18 / 20

Nude with a Red Bird

Frits van den Berghe

1931 · Pen en mengtechniek in zwart op papier · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Frits van den Berghe; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

The title promises a red bird, but the monochrome reproduction cannot supply that colour as visual evidence. What it does show is a figure whose boundaries dissolve into surrounding marks and fantastic shapes. Recognition remains partial. That instability distinguishes the work from the more firmly enclosed bodies elsewhere in this selection.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1973-W-1

19 / 20

Feast at the Doge’s Palace in Venice

Xavier Mellery

1876 · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Xavier Mellery. Feast at the Doge’s Palace in Venice. Image credit: Xavier Mellery; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Xavier_Mellery_-_Feast_at_the_Doge%E2%80%99s_Palace_in_Venice_-_1911-L_-_Museum_of_Fine_Arts_Ghent_(MSK).jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The people occupy only a small part of the decorated hall. Architecture and paintings command a scale that the costumed gathering cannot match, so the room becomes an active participant in the occasion. The effect differs from an intimate tavern scene: here the setting makes social activity appear within an already imposing historical framework.

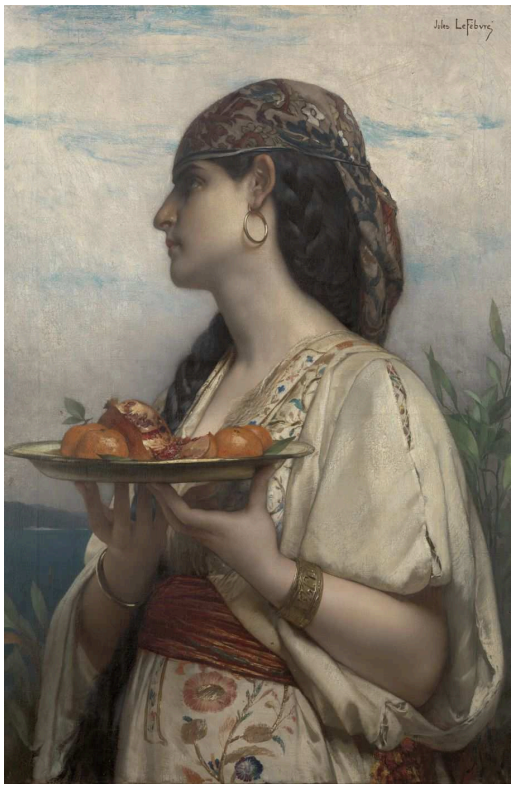
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1911-L

20 / 20

Female Slave with a Plate of Fruit

Jules Joseph Lefebvre

c. 1874 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Fine Arts Ghent



Jules Joseph Lefebvre; Museum of Fine Arts Ghent (MSK). Public Domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Public Domain

The tray, fruit and costume assign the woman a role before the title makes that role explicit. Her profile offers little reciprocal engagement with the viewer. The work can be examined as a staged representation of servitude; the word “slave” in its title does not, by itself, establish the history or identity of the person who modelled.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1874-C

Read the title twice

Try looking first at a figure's action, then returning to the title. Notice what the words clarify and what they add that the image alone cannot establish. These are selected holdings, not a list of guaranteed displays; consult the museum before planning a visit around a particular work.

Further reading

Seven Discourses on Art

Joshua Reynolds · Read free · English

Reynolds’s discourses explain the academic preference for idealized figures and elevated subjects. Read them alongside Bouguereau and the staged historical scenes, while keeping their eighteenth-century assumptions in view.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12